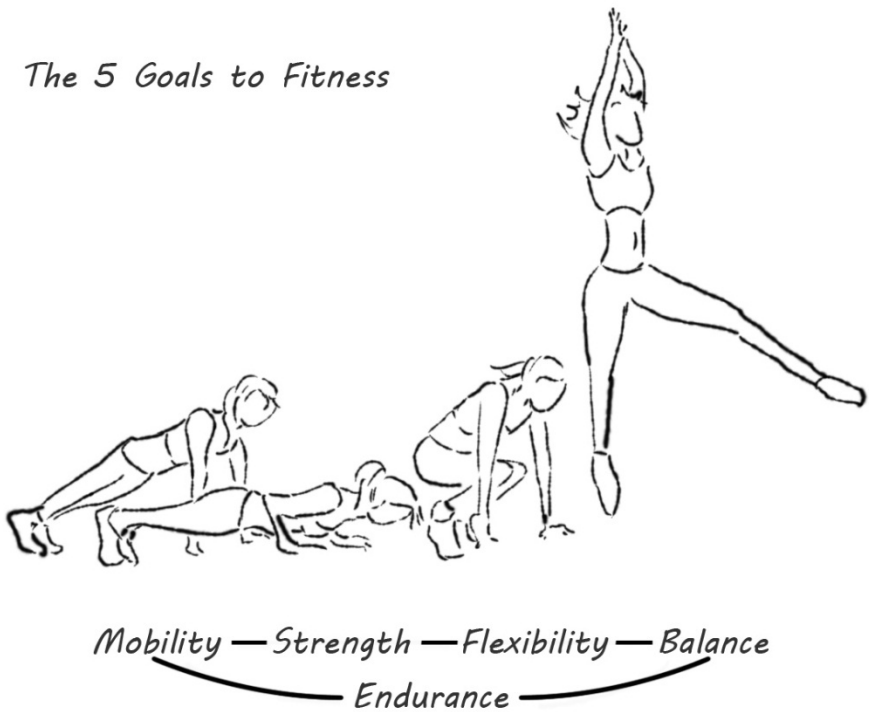
Chapter 4: A Stronger Version of Yourself

It is a universal understanding that being physically fit is paramount to staying young and feeling great. The only way to achieve this goal is through regular exercise. This chapter will encourage you to exercise regularly in an efficient way and with the right spirit.

Fitness—What Does It Mean?



Fitness is a state of health that involves attaining the following physical attributes:

1. Strength—The power in your muscles to do work like lifting, pulling, pushing, and holding on to a position
2. Mobility—The ability to move your body from one position to another. This property encompasses strength and flexibility as well as the element of speed.

3. Flexibility—The ability of muscles and connective tissues to stretch. Flexibility is an essential factor for mobility and the prevention of injuries.
4. Balance—The brain-to-muscle coordination that allows us to hold our position without falling
5. Endurance—The measure of cardiovascular fitness. It is important to gain endurance so you can engage in physical activities without getting too easily exhausted.

Endurance is what most people quite wrongly consider to be "fitness." It is an important element in fitness, certainly, but it is only useful together with strength, mobility, flexibility, and balance. These fitness attributes are best developed and maintained with regular, mindful exercise.

Your Road to Fitness

The purpose of this chapter is to provide you with an understanding of the real purpose of physical exercise. Since we all start at different levels of physical fitness, you will not find textbook prescriptions of which exercise you should do, when to do them, or how long your exercises should take. You will be provided with enough information to plan your own workout and training routines as you develop physically.

Fitness is not about getting thin.

Your Body is Unique

The body is in constant dynamic change. Every individual is unique. Your body will develop on its own terms and respond to exercise in its own way. How it develops varies at different times in your life.

Enjoy your uniqueness. Don't make the mistake of comparing your development with someone else's. Some people grow muscles more quickly than others; some need more cardio to get lean. Others just stay thin and wiry. Contrary to what some exercise gurus might like to have you believe, there is no exercise routine in the world that would work for, or bring the same results to, everyone every time.

You're embarking on a lifelong journey. There is no end point. There is no thirty-day, sixty-day, or ninety-day magic. Exercise

programs that use a time frame make only marketing sense and work mainly to encourage us to exercise consistently for the time period. That is the "pro" of these programs.

The "con" of this is, after that what are you supposed to do?

Having a personal trainer is probably the best way to get started in exercise. If you can afford the expense, it is well worth the money. A good personal trainer will educate you on the right type of moves and the exercises you need to match your present physical condition. He or she can also be a great motivator to keep you on your exercise program.

Not everybody can afford the luxury of having professional help. That is perfectly fine as long as you understand there is such a thing as doing the right kind of exercise and that you need to keep motivated. In the following pages, you will get an idea of how exercise to get fit works. You will also learn how to do it and how to get yourself motivated.

For most of us who are not in the habit of exercising, this is the chapter of greatest challenge. This is also the chapter offering the highest reward.

Start with an open mind. Rethink everything you've been taught about exercise and read on.

Regular exercise is a good way to reduce excess fat, but getting thin is not the point of exercise; rather it is to be young and fit. It is a false belief that thin people are healthier than fat people.

Regardless of our body shape, the majority of us need to set time aside for exercise.

Why We Need Exercise

The Environment

The environment we live in today doesn't engage us adequately to stay fit. We sit in chairs for hours each day. Our muscles don't stretch enough to stay flexible. We don't get to lift anything heavy enough to stimulate the muscles and bones to regenerate and grow. We don't walk on unstable surfaces long enough to regenerate our nerve fibers. Neither do we run, climb, or jump to strengthen our cardiac muscles.

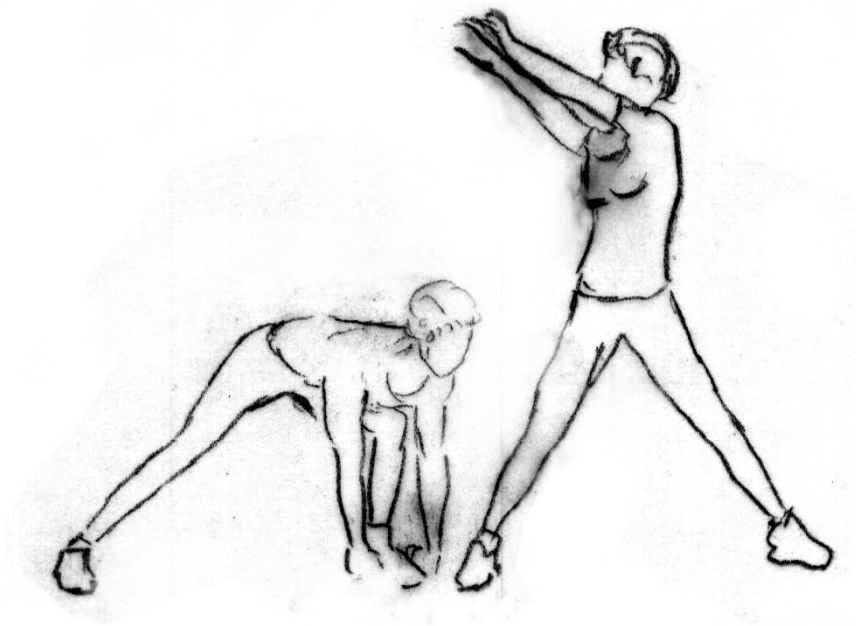
Longer Life Expectancy

Medical science has made it possible for us to live longer. This

advancement poses a challenge for us to live healthy and independently into our nineties. We need exercise to build the physical resources so we can live better as we get older.

Obesity
Our environment is making us fat. Food and lifestyle cause us to store up more energy than ever. Needless to say, fat accumulation is a cause for concern because it leads to chronic illnesses and a poorer quality of life. We need exercise to expend this excess energy.

Stress
Exercise relieves stress. Pumping of blood into muscles stimulates the flow of hormones that, in simple terms, inhibit stress-hormone production. Many of us don't even realize we're living under stress. Stress is dangerous, as we will discuss in later chapters.



How Exercise Really Works in Anti-Aging

Aging is a process of loss whereby attributes of strength, mobility, flexibility, balance, and endurance deteriorate. For most people this

deterioration begins in their early twenties. It is perhaps true that the human body has evolved to gradually lose its level of fitness with age.

This phenomenon is due to the decreased secretion of growth hormones in the body over time. The pituitary gland produces growth hormones. Factors such as age, gender, diet, stress, sleep, and exercise affect the amount of hormones produced in the body.

The good news is that by having the right diet, sleep, stress management, and regular exercise, we can naturally stimulate the production of growth hormones in our own bodies.

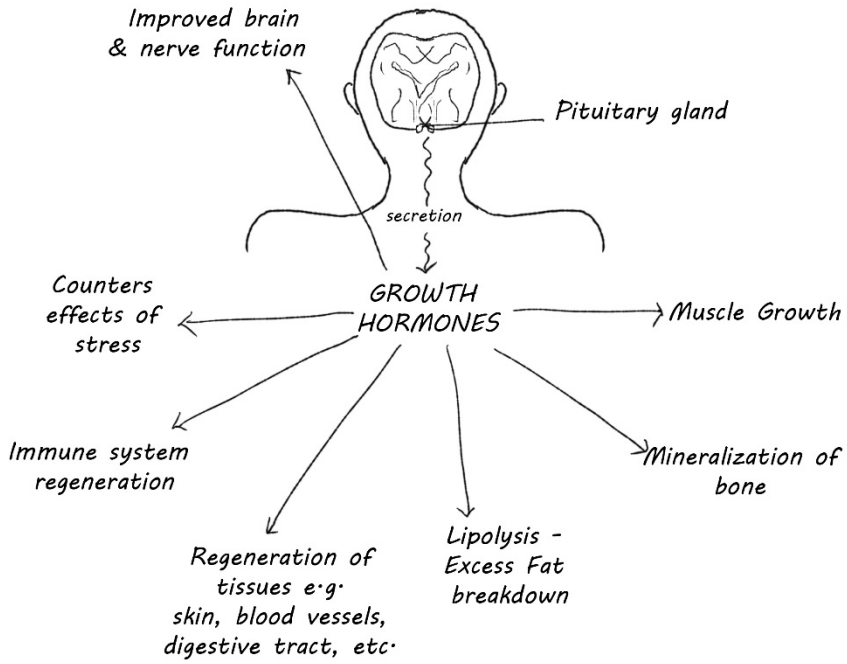
The Function of Growth Hormones

Research has shown that the functions of growth hormones include the following:

- The stimulation of muscle growth
- The increase of bone density
- Lipolysis (the breakdown of fat in fat cells)
- Protein synthesis (for the building of tissues—for example, skin, ligaments, and so forth)
- The stimulation of the immune system
- The decrease of the liver's uptake of glucose and the increase of glucose production for energy
- Homeostasis (balance of body fluid condition in the body);

Growth hormones are responsible for building and replenishing cells and tissues. In humans, these hormones are necessary for growth until we reach reproductive age. When growth is no longer the priority, the body conserves energy by producing fewer and fewer growth hormones.

Lowered growth-hormone production results in reduced ability of the body to rebuild and replenish itself. The results are visible signs of aging.



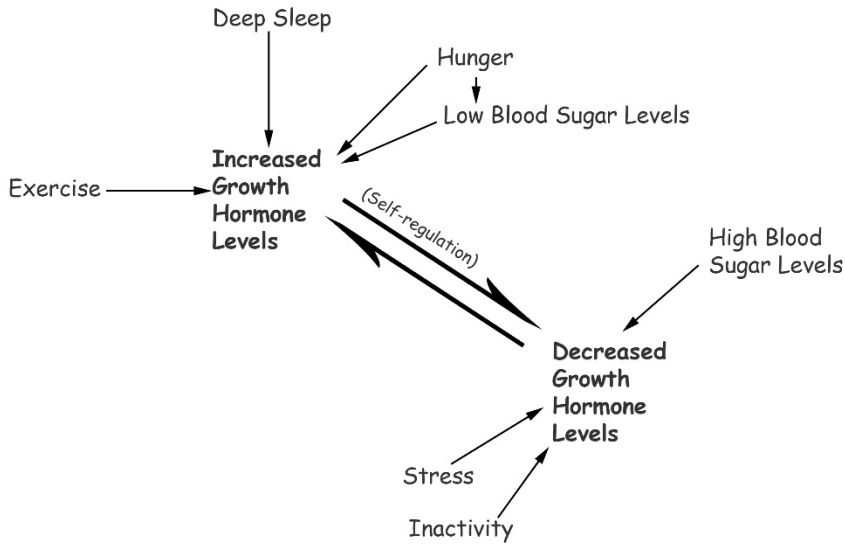
Production and function of growth hormones.

It might seem like we're programmed to gradually shut down. Since we know the physiological effects of growth hormones, we can do something about this problem.

You can stimulate your body to secrete vital growth hormones naturally.

Studies have shown that we can increase our body's natural production of growth hormones through the following activities:

- Participating in regular strength-building exercise
- Controlling blood sugar by cutting refined carbohydrates and sugars from the diet
- Getting adequate amounts of relaxation and deep sleep



This is the reason why people who exercise regularly have an easygoing personality, live a relaxed lifestyle, and tend to look younger than their peers. These people live lifestyles that naturally boost growth hormone levels in their bodies.

The reason for exercise is to cause a rise in human growth hormone levels.

Hormones are chemicals produced in specialized cells in the body. Their function is to transmit messages to their target cells so necessary biological functions can take place. Each hormone is produced in cycles, like the ebb and flow of the waves in the ocean. The human body produces a variety of hormones. These hormones work synergistically to enhance or inhibit the effects and secretion of each other.

Growth hormones are affected by the presence of other hormones. If growth hormones are necessary for maintaining good physical form, then we should try to maintain healthy levels of these hormones.

With the passage of time, lifestyle habits affect the hormonal profile in the body. Knowing the key hormones—their regulation and effects—will guide us toward making healthy choices.

Exercise, Workouts and Training

There is a difference among exercise, workouts, and training.
An *exercise* is a movement you perform. For example, you may do some jumping jacks. That is an exercise.
A *workout* is a series of exercises you may do in succession and in one sitting.
Training is a program of workouts that are planned for a term.

Reps, Sets and Intervals

Reps—or repetition—in exercise is the number of times an exercise is repeated continuously.
A *set* includes a number of reps of the same exercise. This is usually followed by a short period of rest and then another set of the same or different exercise.
An *interval* is the amount of time required to complete a set. It is usually measured in seconds.

Frequency, Duration and Intensity

When planning a workout routine, there are several factors to consider:

Frequency is how often someone works out each week.
Duration is the measure of how long each workout session lasts.
Intensity is how hard someone work. This is normally measured by one's heart rate during exercise and the feeling of exertion.

Get into the best shape of your life. Aim to work out three to four days each week. Make exercising a routine. It will become a habit once you get into the groove of it, and the benefits will become apparent. All you need to do is stick to a plan you set for yourself.

Frequent workouts with few rest days keep your metabolism at a moderately high level, thus enabling the body to naturally burn excess calories. Working out four out of seven days each week may seem like a lot, but the most effective workouts take forty or less minutes to complete. That means less than a total of three hours per week for workout time. That isn't really very much considering how much time most of us spend on the couch, watching television or surfing the

Internet.

Intensity and Duration

Intense, short workouts of twenty to forty minutes per session done three to four times each week are more effective than one three-hour workout done once a week.

The Importance of Rest Days

Rest days are as important as exercise days. During rest the body regenerates itself, builds muscle mass, cleans away toxins, and burns excess fat. You need your rest days, especially if your workouts are intense. On these days it is especially important to have a clean diet (which we will discuss in chapter 5), lots of water, and sufficient sleep.

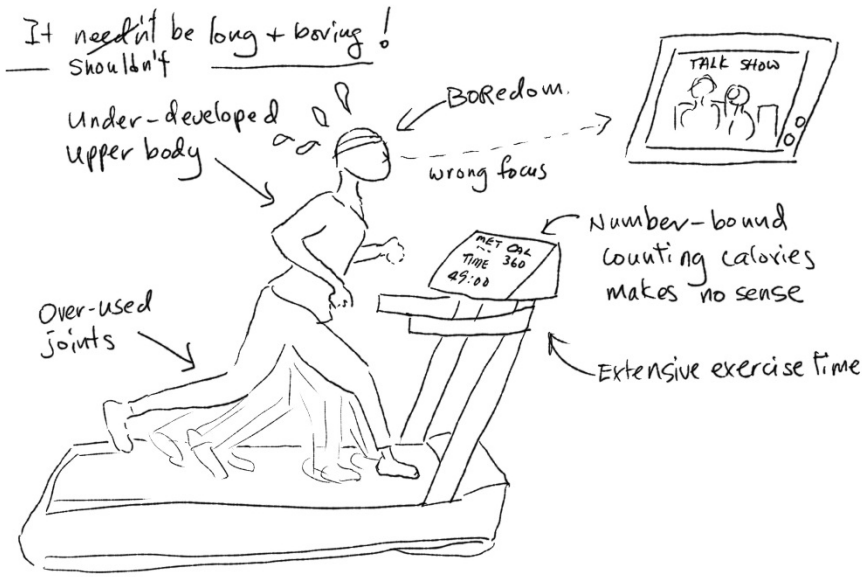
Listen to your body. Rest when you need to rest.

The Weekend Warrior's Pitfall

"Weekend warriors" do nothing physical all week and then decide to run three-hour marathons on the weekends. This routine fails as it does not help build fitness or health. Here's why:

- A three-hour workout done once a week is ineffective in building true physical fitness. If one lasts three hours at a stretch, the person is really not pushing hard enough. Workouts become most effective when the intensity level of the exercise allows no more than a few seconds of continuous movement at a time.
- On and off physical activity often leads to injury. Long periods of lack of exercise tend to leave muscles dormant. Sudden strain on those muscles can lead to injury.
- Long-drawn-out exercises tend to be repetitive. An example of such an exercise is jogging, which involves using the same set of muscles repeatedly with the body weight constantly pounding on the same joints. Instead of building, the exercise is actually wearing out parts of tendon, ligaments, and cartilage.

- Extended workouts drain the body of fuel. When the diet is not in check, the body burns protein together with fat. While burning fat is the aim of the weekend warrior's exercise, the protein depletion eventually becomes his or her undoing. Burning protein depletes muscle and other essential organs, leading to degeneration and aging. Since muscles are the powerhouse of energy burning, losing muscle foils efforts to stay lean.
- You're more likely to miss out on your workout if you allot all your workout time to one session. It is like putting all your eggs into one basket.



Getting-Started Motivation

There are several ways to get regular exercise into your life. Every person can set aside about thirty minutes, four days a week, for

workout by the following:

- Watching forty minutes less of television
- Spending forty fewer minutes on the Internet
- Spending forty fewer minutes chatting
- Hanging out forty fewer minutes in bars, cafés, and shopping centers

Pick one of the above time-wasting habits and decide to dedicate that time to your workout. Make it a routine. Fix that exercise time. Make a plan for the week. Make a workout diary.

The best time of the day to work out is the time of the day you're most likely to work out.

Your Workout Diary

Get yourself a diary just for your workouts. Plotting down a week's workout in advance would help you resist the temptation to do anything ad hoc in place of the session.

After you complete the planned workout, put a check mark beside the date.

In your calendar, plot out your workout schedule a week in advance. This will help you avoid doing anything else in place of exercise.

✓ = Done :)

Plan Your Workout

Before your workout, jot down the type of exercises to do for the session as well as the number of sets and reps for each set or interval. Here are some examples of workout plans:

Workout Plan 1	
Jump-rope	50 secs
Rest	10 secs
Squats	50 secs
Rest	10 secs
Burpees	50 secs
Rest	10 secs
Burpees	50 secs
Rest	10 secs
Repeat x 4 Rounds	

Workout Plan 2	
Jumping Jacks	20 reps
Crunches	15 reps
Burpees	10 reps
Squats	20 reps
Plank Hold	for 30secs
Repeat x 3 Rounds	

Workout Plan 3	
Pushups	4 reps
Crunches	4 reps
Burpees	4 reps
Squats	4 reps
Repeat x 20 Rounds	

You can plan your workout any way you like. Get ideas from the books or the internet. Keep it challenging and fun.

Exercising Right

Your exercise should lead you to a life of youthful fitness and health. There is no other real purpose for doing the exercise other than to stimulate growth-hormone production for replenishing organs and tissues.

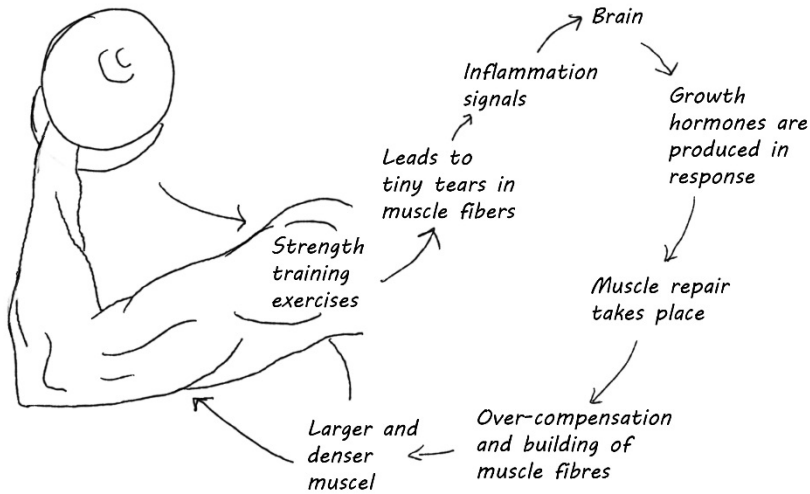
Good exercise is about getting fit. Truly fit.

You will defy the process of aging by looking good, staying lean, being physically stable and mobile, and staving off illnesses linked to the aging process.

Exercises that build muscle mass will ultimately help you keep the fat off. Increasing muscle mass increases your resting metabolic rate (RMR). This means that the more muscle tissue you have in your body, the more calories you burn off throughout the day, even during the time when you're sedentary or asleep.

We shall go through the different exercise concepts to ensure we understand how these actually work.

Strength Training to Grow Muscles

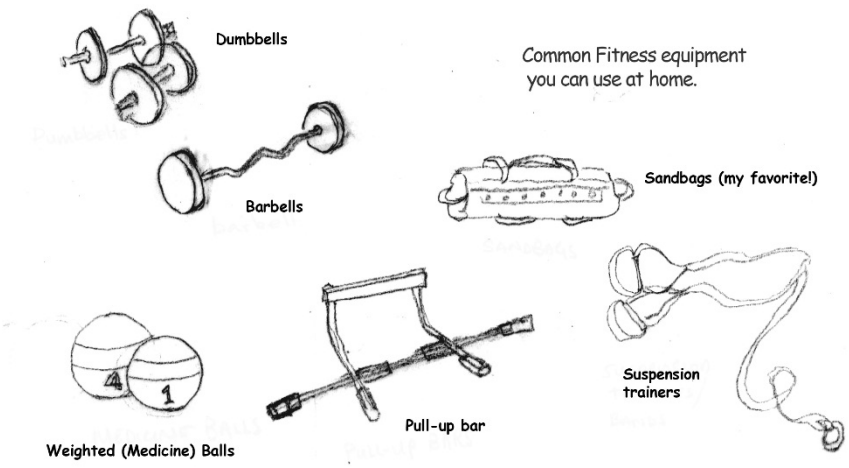


The Effects of Strength Training

Strength training is for everybody. Numerous studies have shown that people, no matter how old or weak, can start to gain muscle strength through strength training. Strength training is also very effective for building muscle mass.

Strength exercises can be done with or without the use of weights. Exercises without the use of weights or equipment is sometimes referred to as body-weight training. Body-weight exercises are the best exercises to do because they are fuss free; there is no need to go to the gym or have any equipment on hand to do body-weight exercises. All you need is a little space to work out.

There is a variety of equipment available on the market for the avid exerciser. All equipment is useful to those who use it.



Weight-training workout routines have the following characteristics:

- They vary in duration. The focus is on lifting, pulling, and pushing. Hence the time needed to complete the workout is not of the essence.
- They vary in intensity. To be effective, weight training must be intense. Work to your maximum for best results.

You can increase intensity in the following ways:

- Increasing weights
- Increasing resistance
- Doing more repetitions
- Doing exercises more quickly or
- Doing exercises dead slow

Weight-training exercise are useful for everybody because

- they are low-impact exercises suitable for most people;
- they are easy to get into if you're an absolute beginner to exercise;
- they build muscle mass quickly and therefore upgrade your growth-hormone production;
- they are ideal for people with cardiovascular issues; and
- they are great for very thin or fat people.

The following pages present examples of effective strength-training, muscle-building exercises. These are done using free weights or just your body weight.

There is so much you can do—so many interesting moves for your

workout. If you're a complete beginner, it would be best to engage a personal trainer. The alternative is to read books dedicated to workouts and exercise or to catch some exercise videos online. There is an updated list of books and links recommended at our website, www.foreveryoungforeverfit.com.

Doing it Right

Strength training is for muscle building. It can come in the form of heavy dumbbell lifting or small controlled movements using your body weight.

Do keep good form at all times. A total beginner at exercise is best advised to engage a trainer or have someone help with the exercise techniques.

Push yourself but don't let ego take over and overstrain. Exercise is effective if there is effort. This effort must be borne out of mindfulness.

Use simple free weights like dumbbells, barbells, sandbags and weighted balls, rather than fancy gym contraptions. These simple equipment neither restrict natural posture nor provide unnecessary support to the body. There is an advantage to this because when free weights are lifted during exercise, the muscles must work hard to keep the body in balance. This extra work will engage entire sets of muscles simultaneously. A balanced musculature is what we want to achieve from our exercise.

Do exercise that include compound movements rather than targeted movement. Compound movements make use of a large group of muscles at a time. This is natural movement. Exercises that use compound movement create balanced musculature. Examples of compound movements include squats, lunges, burpees, lifting free weights, lifting, pulling and pushing heavy objects from one point to another and push or pull-ups. These are actually simple exercises that mimic the kind of movements we engage in daily activity.

Exercise that only "target" individual muscles are best avoided. These exercises include exercise that engages only one set of muscles at a time rather than engaging full sets of muscles simultaneously. Usually these exercises make use of a bench to sit or lie on, and rely on complex gym machines. These are exercises commonly done by body builders for the purpose of building definition in some muscles quickly. The danger of isolating muscles during workout like this is

that while some muscles get pumped up, the others remain weak. This state of imbalance often causes injury. When the exerciser needs to make natural movements in lifting, his or her less developed muscles might overstrain and snap. Do try to understand this philosophy of doing compound exercises and use commonsense while exercising. Think. Do the exercises you're doing feel like natural movement, or do they seem to be awkward?

Exercises should be challenging but they have to feel natural. If a movement causes you to feel discomfort, discontinue the exercise. It could be that the movement is not right for your posture, or it could be that your muscles aren't ready yet. There is such a thing as doing simpler exercises first, then slowly progressing to more advanced workouts. It is better to seek help with training, but if help is not available to you, do some research online or with help of reliable exercise books.

Vary your exercise. It is often tempting to keep doing the stuff you're already good at. That doesn't help keep you really fit and may even leave muscles lopsided. Variation is also more fun than doing the same thing over again. I would recommend using the internet as a resource for good ideas. There are many fitness bloggers and free workout videos for those who want more exercise routines.

Keep Your Movements Natural

When doing strength training, always bear in mind to keep your movements natural. The best exercises are those done with movements

that feel like a natural flow.

Watch your form. Your back should be straight and your torso muscles tight.

Move deliberately. Don't swing or throw.

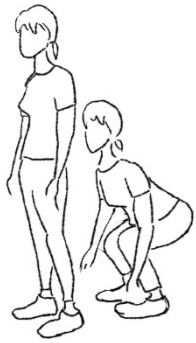
Use appropriate weights. You should feel like you're lifting, pulling, holding, or pushing something that is heavy enough for you to do eight to twenty repetitions at a time.

You may find it necessary to seek advice from a professional to get your form right.

The following two pages illustrate a variety of exercises you can do to work the entire body for true fitness.

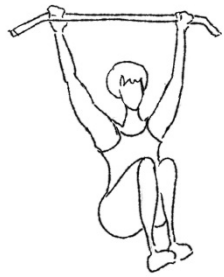
The images in the following pages show some exercises to get you started. These exercises work to reinforce natural body movement. All these moves have a purpose—to strengthen sets of muscles evenly so you can perform daily tasks such as lifting grocery bags, carrying children, getting up from the floor, or climbing a flight of steps with ease. They are compound movement exercises that engages sets of muscles together rather than a single muscle in isolation. You will develop stability and strength from working your body this way.

Body-weight exercises require only the use of your body; you don't need to be in a gym or spend money on equipment. These are exercises you can do anywhere—outdoors, indoors, and even in a hotel room. These exercises are enough to get you fit.



Squats and squat jump variations

Step-ups variations shown here with weights

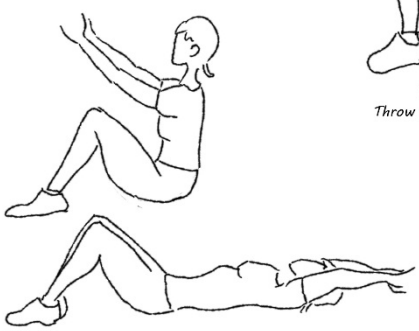


Knee raise wit pull-up bar

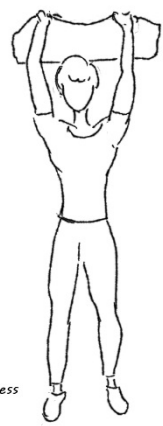
Lunge variation with a weighted ball

Dips (advanced) wit dip bars

Throw and bend with weighted ball

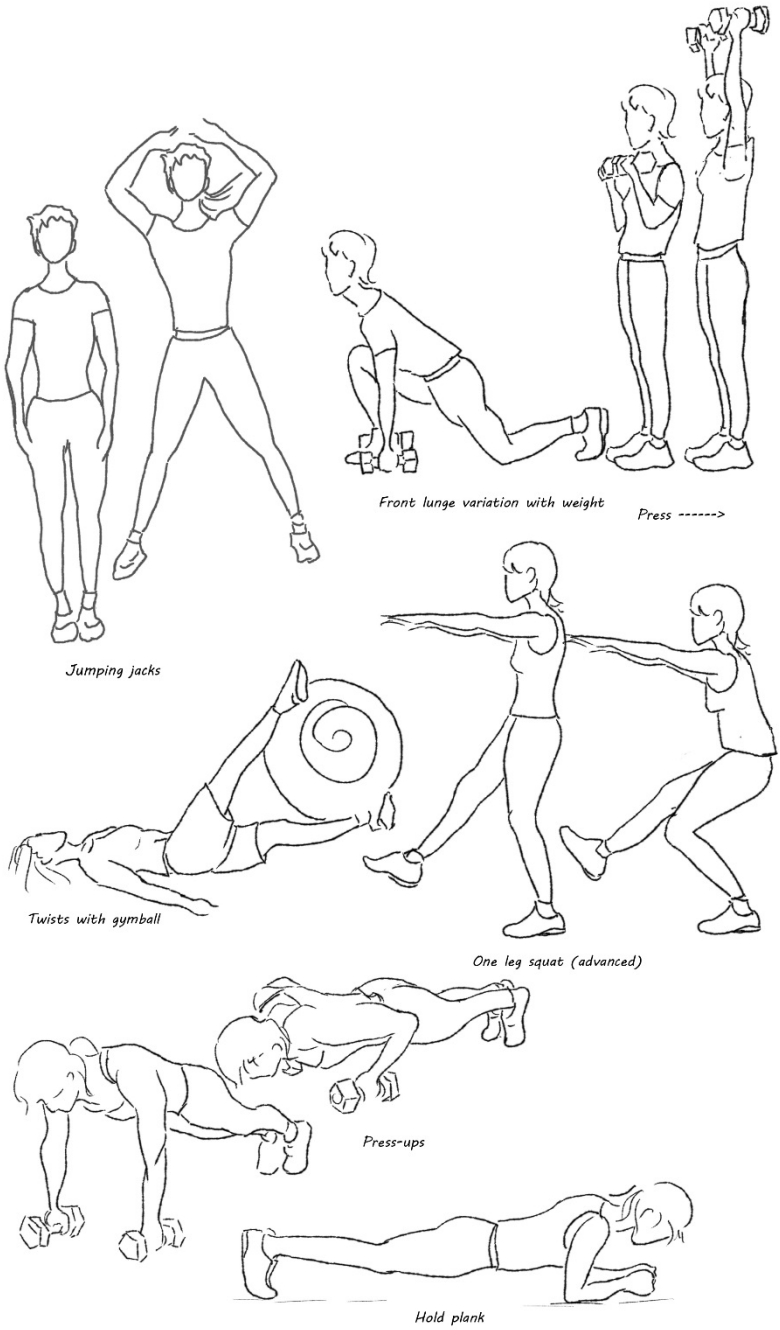


Crunch variation



Sandbag lift and press

Illustrations of the types of exercises we can do with simple or no equipment. Please consult a professional trainer to learn the right forms. The moves should feel natural.



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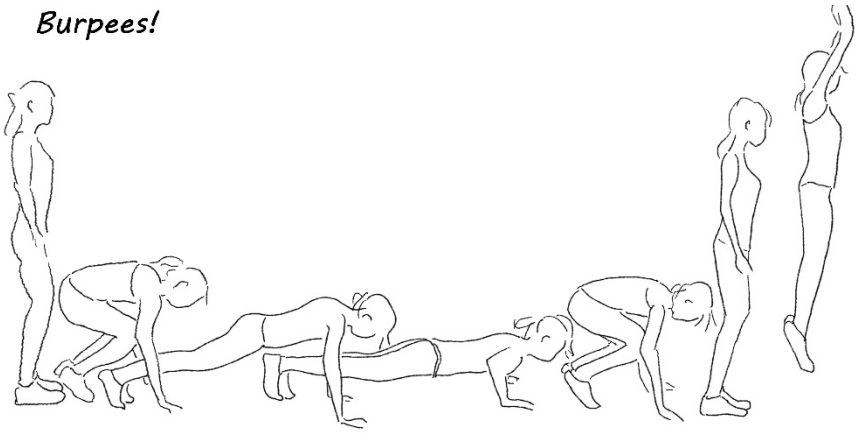


The above exercise move is known to many as a burpee. It is my favorite exercise. This is a great exercise that works the entire body. It strengthens legs, arms, back, and abs. The movement is explosive because you have to repeatedly jump up from the floor and go back down again. This improves cardiovascular endurance. There are also variations we can make with this exercise; for example, we can incorporate push-ups, jump squats, and leg tucks. For beginners, the burpee can be done at a slower pace. For added challenge, we can lift dumbbells and sandbags while doing a burpee. The burpee is ideal for times when you need to warm up or get into a workout mood.

Interval Training for that Cardiovascular Oomph!

Interval-training sessions include very short-duration, high-intensity workouts. Commonly known as high-intensity interval training, or HIIT, these exercises seem like a cross between strength training and cardio exercises, but the focus is on doing as many reps as possible in a specified time (the interval).

The exercises are done with a timer, which is set at twenty to fifty seconds of "work" and ten to thirty seconds of "rest." During the "work" interval, you should do an exercise as quickly as possible. For example, do as many jumping jacks as possible on the beep of the "work" interval until the timer beeps again to start the "rest" interval. Catch your breath on the "rest" interval. On the next beep, do another set of exercises as fast as possible for the "work" interval. Most HIIT workouts last thirty minutes or less. You can get a good session in with just twelve minutes.

HIIT workouts are meant to be intense, and they are most efficient for fast results toward a lean, strong body. They are, however, not suitable for everybody. Absolute beginners might find HIIT almost impossible to do. If that is your experience, keep up the weight training but at a slower pace. Over time you will gain enough strength to do HIIT.

Interval-training workout routines are characteristically short in duration. The main advantage of short workouts is that they don't encroach on your life. Short workouts are easy to keep doing. Everyone can spare minutes in a day for an activity that is so important for maintaining good health.

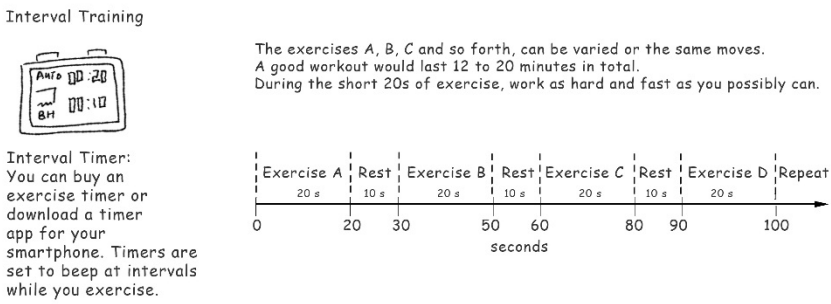
HIIT builds cardiovascular strength. To work to one's fullest effort at every interval, speed and effort are of the essence. The heart rate rises during the "work" interval and recovers during the "rest" interval.

HIIT also builds strength and agility. There is more focus on speed and, depending on the exercise, dexterity. Body-weight exercises like burpees are great additions to interval training.

Due to its intensity, and depending on your level of fitness, interval training is optional and can be incorporated into your workout schedule.

Exercises you can do with HIIT include running sprints, running up the stairs or hills, using a jump rope, doing jumping jacks, using a stationary bike, as well as doing burpees, squats, step-ups, push-ups. Almost any kind of body-weight exercise can be incorporated into a HIIT workout.

There are several ways to plan. Here are some examples to help you understand the concept of interval training.



This is an example of a twelve-minute session. You can change the session time or the intervals:

- Set your timer to ping at twenty-second and ten-second intervals. In the twenty seconds, do an exercise as quickly and with as many repetitions as you can. For the next ten seconds, rest.
- On the ping of the next twenty seconds, do the same exercise or another exercise. For the next ten seconds, rest.
- If you do this for eight rounds, your exercise session will last exactly four minutes. If you really worked as hard as you can, that would be four minutes of intense exercise.
- Repeat this process 3 times, and you would have completed a very intense 12 minute HIIT session.

Here are variations you can make with your workout:

- You may change the intervals—for example, fifty seconds of work and ten seconds of rest or fifty seconds of work and twenty seconds of rest.
- You may do more rounds or fewer rounds (longer or shorter sessions.)
- Change the exercises. Vary the moves.

Interval training is versatile. The only thing to remember is to use your best effort. If you work to the max, your workout session shouldn't exceed forty minutes. Most of us would keep it at less than twenty minutes.

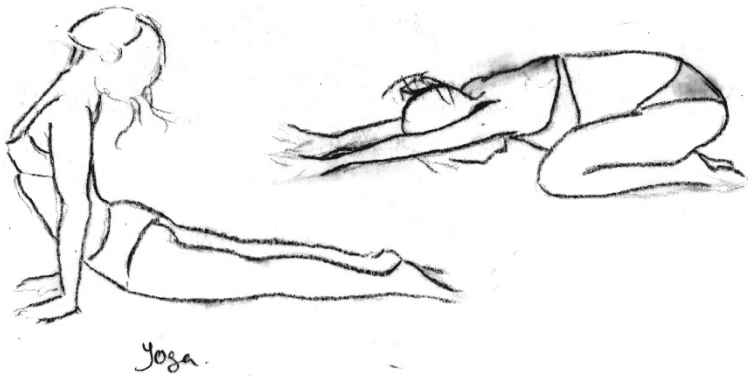
As you get fitter, increase the intensity of the exercise by

- increasing the speed of your moves;
- progressing to more advanced exercises by changing the range of motion or adding weights;
- extending the work interval; or
- shortening the rest interval.

High-intensity interval training has been proved to be the most effective exercise routine to gain strength, mobility, and endurance while burning excess calories in the shortest time.

"If you always put limit on everything you do, physical or anything else, it will spread into your work and into your life. There are no limits, there are only plateaus. And you must not stay there, you must go beyond them." Bruce Lee

Yoga



Yoga exercises combine strength, flexibility, balance, and even meditation. There is less focus on pushing and pulling heavy weights or seeking cardiovascular intensity as in strength training. In yoga, the poses are controlled. The muscles are activated by staying in a contracted state while holding a pose. There is a lot of focus on the form of the body. Doing yoga regularly helps flexibility and balance, two very important aspects of fitness.

If there is movement, each repetition is done at a very slow, controlled pace, with attention to breathing. Duration is usually as long as strength training or longer. More advanced yoga sessions can be up to ninety minutes long. The intensity of exercise in yoga is multilevel. It is not common for weights to be used. In such cases, intensity is increased with more advanced poses and/or a longer length of time by which the pose is held. The advantage of yoga-type workouts is that their movements don't put high impact on the joints. Yoga is ideal for healthy individuals as well as those with special physical needs.

Muscle density can be built with isometric exercises. A long duration of muscle contraction encourages the growth of new muscle fibers—which builds strength.

Regular workouts of this kind encourage growth-hormone production, which in turn brings about anti-aging benefits.

Flexibility exercises that come with most yoga programs enhance mobility like no other.

These exercises are not as aerobic in nature as other types of training. Calories are not "burned" as quickly during workouts.

However, as with other strength-building exercises, muscle mass is built, thereby raising the RMR, which ultimately results in a leaner physique.

With the right program, muscle mass built over time from these workouts will result in strength, mobility, flexibility, and a leaner body composition.

Yoga should be part of your fitness regime. You can incorporate some yoga moves during your rest days or some stretch-and-balance poses as a cool-down routine after a workout.

Vary Your Workout

The body has the tendency to get used to repetitive workouts. To prevent that "plateau effect" and get best results for your efforts, it is important to make variations and change things around every couple of weeks. Here are some changes you can make to your routine:

- Slow down each move. Strength-training exercise gets difficult when done in a dead-slow pace. Try doing a push-up so slowly that you would take thirty seconds to complete a repetition, and you will realize how difficult it is to hold on to the position. Very slow movement engages the muscles for an extended period of time. Holding the muscle in a contracted state keeps the fibers activated. This consumes a lot of energy and results in muscle building.
- Use the interval timer. Vary work and rest intervals. For example, try 20/10 (20 seconds of work+10 seconds of rest) on one day and 50/15 on another day. At the "work" interval, do an exercise as quickly as you can with "as many reps as possible" (AMRAP); during the "rest" interval, rest. Repeat this sequence according to your workout plan.
- Increase the intensity by doing many rounds of exercise or by altering the work/rest interval length.
- Try new exercises. If an exercise sequence gets too easy, your workout will be less effective. That is the time to progress to a more advanced move. There is a huge resource available in books or on the Internet for exercise ideas and techniques if there is no personal trainer available to help you with new workouts.
- Change your exercise environment. If you usually exercise indoors, try going outdoors. Try working out at a playground,

at the beach, or in a field. When you change your environment, you will find new terrain and things to do a new workout with.
- Change the hour of your workout.
- Try new equipment. Best are different types of free weights. These include dumbbells, barbells, clubbells, etc.

A change in workout parameters gives the body added challenge. When there is a challenge, the workouts remain effective.

This book covers only some important exercises. There is, however, an infinite amount of things the human body can do. As long as you focus on building strength, mobility, flexibility, balance, and endurance, you can get creative.

Get inspiration online. The Internet is a great resource for workout routines. Do check out our website for links to exercise routines for all levels.

"It's not the mountain that lies ahead of you that stops you… It's the pebble in your shoe." Muhammad Ali

Work As Hard As You Can

A good attitude pays. Once you have set that amount of time for exercise, do the best you possibly can. Keep your mind focused on building strength, mobility, flexibility, balance, and endurance. Forget about losing weight, because that will naturally happen for you with your new lifestyle.

Think of yourself as a warrior. Tell yourself you're made of great energy. Give your best effort and form for every repetition. Keep your head up. No matter how exhausted you're, stay positive. Complaining and telling yourself you're weak are wasted efforts that will limit the effectiveness of your workout.

Visualize how great you will feel after the session. The harder you work, the better the feeling.

While exercising, put your body in a flow of movements. Enjoy the energy you have in you.

The difference between someone who sees improvement in body composition and one who goes to the gym for years and doesn't get any fitter is the mind-set one has during the workout sessions. The former sees himself as a warrior with fitness goals to conquer, while the latter is a victim of exhaustion.

If you think like a warrior while working out, you build like a warrior. A victim will look like a victim. Be positive. Think positively. Your mind will give your muscles added energy to move right and grow.

Exercise Will Get Easier with Practice, but Your Workouts Should Stay Challenging

The more you repeat an exercise, the easier it will be to do. That is the time to start doing something different. The body has a tendency to adapt and get used to some exercise routines. No single repetitive exercise can fulfill all goals for the long term. Along the way you will need to do different types of workouts to keep getting better.

Keep going. Every individual is unique. Depending on your workout routine or on whether you get help from a professional, signs of success will appear at different time frames.

Keep your focus. Follow the advice in this chapter.

Most importantly, give yourself time. It may be weeks or months. Just keep working out.

Fitness is a lifestyle; this is a lifelong habit. There is no end point. Keep working out regularly and in the right way, and you will stay forever young, forever fit.

The Mind-Body Connection in Exercise

Exercise is physical activity with a mental connection. When we exercise the body with the right state of consciousness, we're doing it mindfully. Mindfulness during exercise brings great rewards; lack of it results in wasted hours of workouts without observable improvement in physical condition.

There are effectively two extreme kinds of people who say they exercise regularly. The first are those who spend hours at classes or on machines but don't seem to see any significant improvement in their body composition after months of gym membership. Their method of working out is commonly seen in individuals who spend hours running or pounding on treadmills, elliptical machines, or stationary bikes. Another group spends hours in aerobic classes because they are fun.

Their reason for working out is usually to "burn calories," "lose weight," or "do some cardio." Most of them are number bound, transfixed on calorie-counting gadgets and heart-rate monitors.

The problem with this attitude toward exercise is that the effect won't last. After months of doing the same exercises, the body gets used to the workout. Since there is no variation, some parts of the body get more developed than others. For example, runners tend to have weak shoulders and arms because few of them care to do push- ups or carry weights.

The other problem with long bouts of cardio, as mentioned earlier, is the burning out of muscles and the wearing out of joints.

When the body gets efficient in doing these exercises, the exerciser gets the sense of getting fit. But the fact is, he is not really getting fit because fitness is not merely about cardiovascular endurance. True fitness is about strength, mobility, flexibility and balance as well.

This is the reason why some people claim they work out but still have problems with fat accumulation.

In the second group are individuals who exercise mindfully and get stunning results (in the form of a lower body fat percentage and an increase in lean body mass) from their workouts. Mindful exercise involves focusing on movement, intensity, and form; doing a variety of exercises; and putting in maximum effort at each session, with the goal of becoming truly fit (in other words, building muscle for strength, mobility, flexibility, balance, and endurance.). This way of exercising brings observable improvement to physique and ultimately to youthfulness.

The difference between the two groups is in their extent of mindfulness when they exercise. You would want to be a member of the second team. While all kinds of exercises will work in the immediate term, most random workout routines will not work for the long term. This is a phenomenon called "hitting the plateau." That is because the human body has a way of getting used to repetitive exercises.

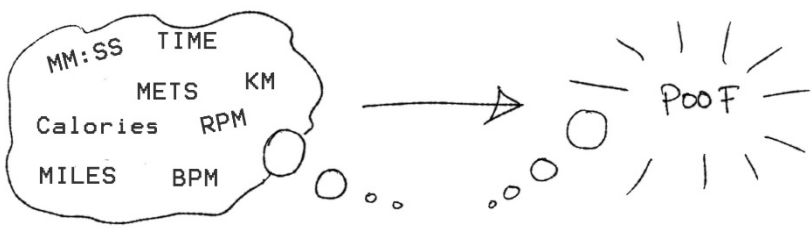
MINDFUL EXERCISE	REPETITIVE EXERCISE
Focus on movement and form	Focus on numbers
Builds strength, mobility, fexibility, endurance, balance -- Fitness	"Fat Burning"
Intensity	Time
Variation	Repetitive
Full body focus	No focus on body
Results in muscle building, tissue and bone regeneration	Burns fat and other tissues
Gain muscle mass, increase RMR	Lose muscle mass, decrease RMR
Short workout sessions	Long workout sessions

Workouts for any reason other than building strength, mobility, flexibility, and endurance are not going to get you really fit.

On the flip side, when you do exercise mindfully, you get the maximum benefit for your efforts. Your body will be leaner, stronger, and more flexible. You will find performing daily tasks to be easier. You will feel more energetic, more in the mood to take part in spontaneous activity. That kind of approach to exercise will give you real, long-lasting fitness.

Do not become number bound.

Don't fall into the trap of getting number bound. Numbers are pure illusions that don't reflect real human physiology.



Forget numbers while exercising

Exercise becomes more effective when the mind is free of numbers and more focused on how the body moves.

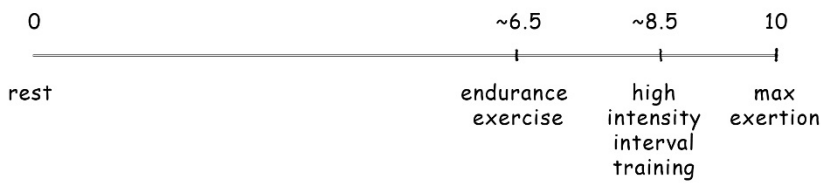
The human body is not an inanimate engine but a complex machine that runs on closely regulated biochemical reactions.

You don't "burn" six hundred calories simply because the treadmill says so. Exercise machines are created with gimmickry to make the user reliant on it with the purpose to sell more exercise machines.

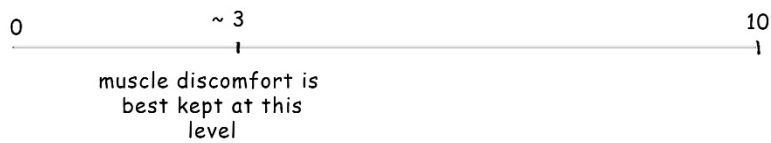
The same is true for heart-rate monitors. If you learn how to feel your body during your workout, you will know when you've reached your maximum heart rate.

Estimate the level of your workout with a 0 to 10 scale. This scale is an estimation of the level of exertion during exercise.

Exertion - heart rate & breathing during exercise:



Feeling of muscle discomfort during exercise:



Learning how to feel your body is an important step. You have to know your potential and your limits. There is such a thing as under exercising and over exercising, both of which would not bring the full benefits of the exercise.

You can use the technique of perceived exertion to gauge the intensity of exercise. It is an arbitrary scale of zero to ten, with zero being how you feel at the point of rest and ten being how you would feel at the point of complete exertion.

Learning to feel your body will free you from being bound to numbers. This freedom will make the workouts more effective in attaining your true fitness goals.

Fitness is the Best Purpose for Exercise

Exercise is a double-edged sword. It is like a risky investment. How well you benefit from the time you put aside for your workouts will determine the extent of your success.

Be aware that exercise can be a time-wasting, self-destructive activity if done with the wrong focus—for example, like the focus on mindlessly burning away calories. Burning calories without building muscles ages the body and does nothing to improve overall fitness.

Effective exercise is different because it is done with the right mind-set—with the constant focus on getting fit. Exercise with this kind of attitude will bring long-lasting rewards.

Work out regularly with the aim of gaining the five attributes of fitness—strength, mobility, flexibility, balance, and endurance. You will find your body getting healthier, leaner, and more youthful.

Physical vitality has a profound influence in all other aspects of your life. You will feel more confident, happy, and self-sustaining.